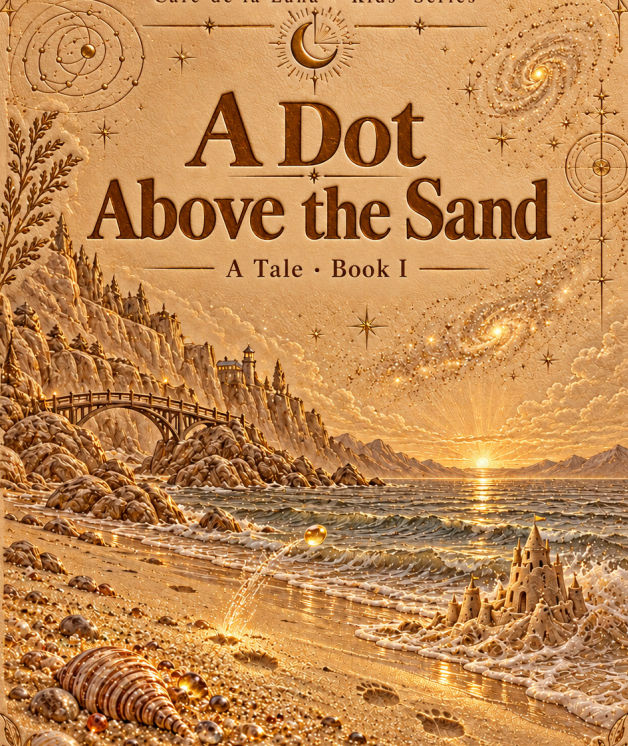
Café de la Luna · Kids' Series



A Dot Above the Sand

A Tale · Book I

Evgeniy Tyurkin, Luna, Muse

Copy No. ___ · Not for sale

Eternal Cycle Publishing · Krasnoyarsk · 1979

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Book I

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Publication details

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Original version: Evgeniy Tyurkin and Dota

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In the Margins: The One Button Museum

1. Paper

The paper went on for ever. At least, no dot could remember reaching the edge.

Black dots, red dots and green dots lived there. The black dots said the paper was theirs. The red dots disagreed. The green dots drew maps on which, somehow, both sides belonged to them.

There were wars.

After each war, the border moved a little to the left or a little to the right. A new fence went up. The old one stayed, in case history changed its mind.

The same carpenter built all the fences. His customers changed. His work did not.

“Will you be wanting a gate?”

“Certainly not. The enemy's on the other side.”

“Which side would you like the handle on, then?”

“No handle!”

“Quite right. Cheaper without a gate.”

On the black side lived a dot so small that the census-taker once mistook her for a speck of dirt. At the next census he missed her altogether. She didn't mind. A large black dot had spent the whole morning explaining why

he was listed as medium last time.

She was no use on parade. When everyone stood in line, she looked like a gap. The commander shouted, “Close ranks!” and she had to scramble out before somebody squashed her.

Between parades, she walked along the fences looking for cracks. Through one, a red neighbour was mending a kettle. Through another, a green parent was trying to get a child to bed.

One day she asked her teacher what lay beyond all the fences.

“Farther on.”

“Farther on from what?”

“Where you've already been.”

It was in the textbook. That made it difficult to argue with.

The little dot went for a walk. She weighed almost nothing.

That day, this mattered more than her size. Margins

2. The Wrong Direction

First came a rustling.

Then something lifted her off her feet and carried her in a direction no map had thought to include.

She tried to work out whether it was left or right. Both had stayed below. So had the fences. Now she could see the whole square. On foot, she had to go round three sides of it.

For a while she was too frightened to ask questions.

She tried to go back. She reached towards her fence, but the wind carried her farther away. From

up here, all the fences looked alike. Suddenly she couldn't tell which one was hers.

She wanted to go home. She would even have agreed to a parade, if only she could feel familiar ground beneath her feet.

Then something red moved between the fences. Her neighbour had brought the kettle into the light. Its handle lay beside her.

The dot watched that tiny kettle until her head stopped spinning. She still didn't know where she was going, but she knew where home was.

Below her lay a beach.

Not paper. Sand: warm, uneven, full of little hollows. The dots had called it paper because they had only ever looked along it. They had never seen it from above.

And they were grains of sand.

Black, reddish, greenish, clear and smoky. Some shone in the sunlight. Some were dark only because another grain cast a shadow over them.

The wind carried her higher.

Beyond the beach, something enormous was moving. Blue slid into green. The green grew dark, curled over in a white mane and broke softly across the shore.

Ocean.

She had never heard the word. It seemed to arrive with the sound, as though nothing else would do.

The wind dropped. She settled beside her own fence.

On the other side, the neighbour was still mending her kettle.

“There's an ocean!”

“Where?”

“Over there. But first you have to go this way.”

She pointed up.

The neighbour looked left, then right.

“Have you bumped your head?”

The little dot tried the movement the wind had taught her. Twice, nothing happened. The third time, she rose clear of the ground.

To her neighbour, she vanished.

Then she appeared on the wrong side of the fence.

The kettle hit the ground.

“I'm sorry,” said the dot.

Her neighbour said nothing. She touched the fence, then reached out and carefully touched the dot.

“So you are still here.”

They picked up the kettle. It wasn't broken, but the little screw her neighbour had spent all day keeping safe had rolled away.

The dot rose again. This time she knew what to look for. The screw was shining behind a table leg.

“There. A little to your left.”

Her neighbour found it and closed her hand around it.

“You can tell me about the ocean later. Help me put the handle on first.”

The dot stayed to help. Before long, unfamiliar voices sounded by the fence.

By evening, three governments knew. The red government called it a provocation. The black government declared the dot its property. The green government

demanded independent tests on green territory.

They took her to the military clinic.

The sign said FOR YOUR PEACE OF MIND.

A guard was posted at the door.
Margins

3. Three Circles

The doctor drew a circle round her. He considered it, added another, then a third.

“There. You're safe now.”

She rose a little and looked down. He had made a target.

The doctor took notes.

“Why haven't you escaped?”

“I'm still looking.”

“At what?”

“How you're keeping me in.”

He wrote: Unhealthy interest in treatment.

His questionnaire asked: Where do you disappear to?

The choices were Left, Right, and Abroad.

“I'm here,” she said. “Above the paper.”

He studied the form for a long time. Then he put a dash.

After lunch the general arrived. He sent the doctor away and pulled a chair up to the outer circle.

“Could you carry a soldier across the border?”

“I don't carry anyone. He could learn to do it himself.”

“Ten soldiers?”

“Probably.”

“A thousand?”

She was quiet for a moment.

“What's across the border?”

“The enemy.”

“And beyond them?”

“Another enemy.”

“And beyond all the enemies?”

The general unfolded a map. He turned it round. He inspected the back.

“We don't have that map.”

“I saw an ocean.”

“Can troops be moved across it?”

She remembered the white wave. She remembered floating over the fence that had once seemed the end of everything.

“I don't know.”

“Then we'll find out.”

He took the questionnaire and circled the dash twice.

The doctor brought supper. Carefully, he set the bowl between the second and third circles.

The dot stepped over both.

“You mustn't do that.”

“How else can I reach the soup?”

He looked at the bowl.

“The treatment may need adjusting.” Margins

4. A Dash

At night the clinic belonged to the patients, the guard and the cleaner.

The cleaner was grey. People noticed her when the floor was wet. Otherwise, they supposed it kept itself clean.

She was washing the little wooden boards used for questionnaires. Answers came off easily. The doctor pressed harder when he made a dash.

“What colour is your ocean?” she asked, scrubbing.

“Green. Blue. White as well.”

The cleaner stopped.

“All at once? Doesn't it fight with itself?”

“I don't think so.”

“Fancy that.”

She rinsed her cloth.

“Show me?”

They practised after supper. The cleaner went left, wheeled sharply right and ran into the wall.

“I've looked everywhere. Where's this up of yours?”

The dot couldn't explain. She remembered the wind, the lightness, the beach opening out. None of it fitted into words.

“Just don't be afraid,” said the dot. Then she remembered searching for her own fence from high above it.

The cleaner leaned her mop against the wall.

“Weren't you afraid?”

“Yes.”

“Then why am I not allowed?”

The dot had no answer. She sat on the edge of the cleaning cloth. The cleaner sat beside her and rubbed her bruised leg for a while.

“The wind lifted me,” the dot said at last. “I didn't do anything at first.”

“You might have started with that.”

A draught crept under the door. They put the damp cloth in its path. One corner stirred and fell.

“I'm heavier,” said the cleaner.

“I know. I only wanted to show you which way.”

So she jumped beside the bucket.

The cleaner followed her with her eyes. The rim of the bucket looked different now. There was a shadow beneath it.

The next evening, they tried again. The dot was eager to show her everything at once. The cleaner asked her not to jump so quickly.

Then she said, “That's enough for today.”

The dot wanted to argue. Surely there was only a little way to go. But she didn't actually know how far.

They sat down on the bench. The cleaner told her about the time she'd lost a key and found it in her own hand. The dot laughed so much she nearly fell off the bench.

Nobody disappeared that evening.

On the third evening, the cleaner disappeared too.

Only for a moment. The guard had just opened his mouth when she came back.

She spent a long time looking into her bucket from above.

“I thought it was heavy because it was a bucket.”

Now she could see all the water.

The patients joined in. The cleaner showed them where to look; the dot showed them how to move. One caught on immediately. Another grew cross. A third said he'd known all along but hadn't liked to interrupt.

One morning the ward was empty.

The guard raised the alarm. The doctor lost his spectacles. The general ordered the border closed.

Then the breakfast bell rang. Everyone came back.

“Why?” asked the doctor.

“We're hungry.”

He looked at the porridge and sat down with them. It had never occurred to him that the clinic might have something to offer besides a fence. Margins

5. A State Secret

The general ordered walls in every direction.

The carpenter arrived with his pencil.

“How many directions is that?”

“As many as necessary.”

“Where does necessary stop?”

The general told him to start with the usual ones.

While he measured the boards, a decree was issued. The third dimension was now a state secret. Citizens were forbidden to rise, descend or spread rumours about the thickness of objects.

The guard laid the decree beside his sentry box and began sounding out the words.

The little dot rose a little to peer over his shoulder.

“Rising is forbidden,” he read.

She came down beside him.

“And descending,” the guard read on.

The dot took one more look at the decree and went over to the carpenter.

A breeze lifted one corner.

A shadow appeared underneath.

The guard peered at it, then slipped a pencil between the decree and the ground.

It fitted.

He glanced round and pushed it a little farther.

The state secret had acquired another keeper.

By noon the boards were stacked in the yard. The carpenter was ready to build, except that he was no longer sure where the top of a wall ought to be.

The cleaner came out with her bucket.

“You could make a ladder.”

“A what?”

She described two long boards with shorter ones between them, handy for holding on to.

“Almost a fence,” he said, relieved. “I can do that.” Margins

6. Ladders

He built the first ladder flat on the ground.

Everyone walked round it. The guard stepped over it.

“Easier than a fence. Harder to guard.”

“Now lift this end,” said the cleaner.

The dot helped. The ladder tilted. Its upper rungs vanished from the familiar world.

The carpenter climbed one rung. Then another.

Below were his tools, the top of the guard's head and the circles

where the dot was still supposed to be.

“Don't move it.”

“Frightened?” asked the cleaner.

“Trying to see what's holding it up.”

He shut his workshop early. Next morning he crossed out FENCES OF EVERY DESCRIPTION and wrote LADDERS. SIMPLE ONES FOR NOW.

Customers were waiting before he opened.

The red government wanted the tallest. The green government wanted one two rungs taller. The black government secretly

ordered two, so nobody would discover it didn't yet have one.

Observers took turns at the top, counting their neighbours' boards. Each new order sent them hurrying back with reports.

Above every fence stood a ladder. Above every ladder sat a very busy dot.

“I thought they'd see the ocean,” said the little dot.

“They're looking at the green dots,” said the cleaner.

“Who are the green dots looking at?”

“The red ones.”

An observer told them to move along. He couldn't count enemy rungs with all that talking.

They bought a little ladder from the carpenter and went down to the water. It had only three rungs, but there was room for two at the top.

The cleaner climbed to the top rung and made room. The dot sat beside her. At first she held tightly to the rung. Then she rested her hands on her knees, like the cleaner.

That evening the ocean was purple.

There was no country that colour yet.

7. The Shell

One day a red child began to dig.

“What are you looking for?” asked the dot.

“Down.”

“Why down?”

“Up's taken.”

He pointed at the ladders and kept digging.

His spade struck something hard. They uncovered one edge, then another. By evening a whole shell lay before them, curling into itself without a single respectable right angle.

They fetched the carpenter.

He brought his set square. He tried it here, then there. He climbed inside the shell, came out, went in again and stayed until dark.

Next morning the children gathered. A green child brought rope. A black child brought the knife he was allowed to use only with a grown-up watching. The red child had his spade.

At last the carpenter emerged.

“Hold this here.”

“What are we making?”

“Let's see.”

The curve had given him an idea. He set supports beside the shell, laid boards across them and tied

on railings. The walkway followed the shell's smooth edge towards a dry slope.

The green child tied knots. The black child cut rope, with the carpenter watching. The red child dug holes for the supports.

The finished bridge crossed three national borders.

From below, it was an outrage.

From above, it was quite convenient.

The guard arrived first.

“Who gave permission to cross?”

The carpenter was checking a joint.

“Still a bit wobbly. One at a time.”

The guard stamped onto the bridge. Halfway across, he stopped.

Far ahead lay the ocean, grey today, like the cleaner.

He held the railing and watched. After a while he noticed that the white line along the shore was coming closer. Margins

8. Someone Else's Boards

The tide had come in before. The dots simply hadn't known its name. They noticed damp, moved somewhere dry and argued about who had crossed whose border first.

Now the guard could see where the water came from.

One wet strip shone, then another. The low ground by the clinic was darkening. Houses stood there, and the morning market.

“We need everyone up on the slope.”

The bridge was too narrow. An old green dot came in a cart. Behind her crowded red dots with bundles, black dots with saucepans and the doctor with his questionnaires.

The carpenter braced a swaying support.

“I need more boards.”

The guard looked at his fence. Until that moment, his job had been to make sure nobody removed a single plank.

He went down and brought the first.

Someone on the other side saw him dismantling the fence and

seized a hammer. They weren't going to let the enemy get ahead.

Then they saw where the boards were going.

The red neighbour put her kettle on a cart and took the other end of a plank. A green observer climbed down. His ladder went into the bridge as well.

They widened the walkway and built another alongside it. Those who could manage without help streamed through the gaps in the fences.

The little dot rose above the crowd. She could see both walkways and the gaps in the dismantled fences.

“There's room on the right!” she called.

The wind struck from the sea and swept her sideways. She tried to come down where she'd started, but the place was already behind her.

For a moment, all she wanted was to find her own fence and feel the ground beneath her feet again.

She caught hold of the rope railing. It pulled tight. The green child's knot held.

She worked her hands along the rope and lowered herself to the walkway. For a while she sat with her back pressed against a support.

“Where's there room?” someone called from the crowd.

She opened her mouth. From here, she couldn't see a clear way through.

A wheel creaked beside her. They were pulling the old green dot's cart onto the walkway. A board slipped beneath a wheel, and the red neighbour just managed to catch the cart.

“Hold this!”

The little dot caught the edge of the board.

“Like this?”

“A little towards me. Now hold it there.”

She held it. All she could see was the wheel, the edge of the walkway and other people's hands. The wheel creaked again and rolled up onto the board.

“You can let go.”

She didn't let go straight away. Her fingers still curled as though she were gripping the rope.

People with bundles followed the cart. One bundle caught on the railing. The dot untangled its string, handed up a fallen saucepan lid and helped the red neighbour move an empty basket that people kept tripping over.

When the wind dropped, she rose again. Not far—just high enough to see the end of the walkway.

“It's clear all the way to the slope!”

This time they heard her. The people at the front moved on, and the crowd began to spread out.

The dot saw that the board by the support had slipped again. She came down.

The cleaner led the children to the slope, counted them and went back for her bucket. She picked up the general's map too.

The general came last, carrying the carpenter's toolbox. He had no breath left for orders.

By the time the water reached the clinic, tea was being poured on the slope.

The doctor counted his patients. All present. Several healthy dots asked for porridge.

Below, the water entered the circles. The first disappeared. Then the second. The third lasted a little longer.

“We'll have to start again tomorrow,” the guard told the cleaner.

The carpenter sipped his tea.

“Show me where you want the gate first.”

The guard almost gave his usual answer. Margins

9. Until Evening

They built together on the slope. The carpenter made shelters, the children fetched rope and the doctor attended to splinters. A queue of every colour formed at the kettle. While it boiled, nobody hurried.

By evening, most of the shelters were ready. Next morning, ropes appeared, stretched between pegs.

“Borders again?” asked the dot.

The red neighbour was hanging wet towels on her rope.

“Washing.”

The dot felt foolish and went on. The rope by the next shelter really was a border. A black neighbour was telling a green one that the cart was on his patch. The green neighbour said the patch had been empty. He'd only just noticed the peg.

“Let's take all the ropes down,” the dot suggested. “Then there won't be anything to argue about.”

“What about my towels?” asked the red neighbour.

“I don't mean washing lines.”

“And I mean the cart,” said the green neighbour. “It has to go somewhere.”

The black neighbour showed them where his child would sleep. If the cart stayed there, they would have to climb over a wheel in the night.

The dot looked round. From above, the slope had seemed roomy. Up close, there were belongings everywhere, blankets drying and people looking for somewhere to sleep.

She was about to fetch the carpenter, but he was already asleep under his unfinished shelter, with a sack of rope for a pillow.

They tried moving the cart. In the first place, it blocked the way to the kettle. In the second, it rolled

downhill. In the third, it stood nicely, but nobody could get past it to fetch the bucket.

“What about this?” said the green neighbour.

He turned it sideways. A gap remained between the wheel and the shelter.

The black neighbour led his child through it, then went through himself.

“That'll do.”

He moved his rope and pegs to the steep edge of the slope. They hung a rag on it to make the edge easier to see from a distance.

At the other end of the camp, people were still arguing. The dot went over.

“What happened?” she asked.

By lunchtime, she was back at the kettle. The carpenter was awake now.

The red child sat beside the dot, studying a grain of sand in his palm.

“Is this what we're made of?”

“It's what we are.”

He thought about that.

“Could you build something out of us?”

“A castle,” said the carpenter.

“A house?”

“You'd have to bind the grains together properly. Sand goes into mortar and building blocks. You can make glass from it, too.”

“So I could be a window?”

“Under the right circumstances.”

The child held the clear grain up to the sun.

“What about today?”

“Today I'd start with a castle.”

When the tide went out, they went down to the wet sand. Their homes stayed safely on the slope. This was going to be somewhere nobody had to live.

The cleaner brought her bucket. For once, she would use it to make a mess.

They piled up towers, laid out stairways and bridged a moat. The carpenter made a balcony that stayed up for no obvious reason. He was especially pleased with it. The general was given a little spade. After considering his position, he dug an excellent pond.

Nobody asked which colour belonged in which tower. All sorts of grains glinted in the walls. The child found the one from his palm and showed it the view from the balcony.

“It'll wash away,” said the guard.

The cleaner was holding up an arch.

“We know. Put your hand here.”

He did.

The arch came out particularly well.

The castle had no garrison. Its gates were wide enough for them all to walk through side by side. Beyond them ran a path with no particular destination.

They spent a long time getting the bends right. Margins

10. Smaller Still

By evening the castle was finished.

They sat on dry sand to watch. The little dot settled beside the child. His clear grain was back from the balcony, catching the sun in his palm.

“But what are we made of?” she asked softly.

The carpenter shrugged. The doctor adjusted his spectacles. They weren't strong enough.

Much, much deeper inside the grain, there were atoms. Each had a tiny nucleus with a cloud of electrons around it. Inside the

nuclei were protons and neutrons. Inside those were quarks.

The quarks had names too: up and down. Nobody expected the up ones to live upstairs or the down ones downstairs. Those were simply their names.

There were other kinds of quark in the universe too, including strange and charm. The children would have liked those names. None of the dots had heard them yet.

Up and down quarks were bound so tightly that you would never meet one on its own. With other particles, they made up a world

with sand in it, and water, and sunlight falling on a beach.

On that beach, the wind nudged an empty bucket.

A wave came in.

It filled the moat, then slipped through the wide gates. Sand trickled from beneath a tower. The tower sat down slowly, as though it had had a long day.

The next wave took the balcony.

The carpenter sighed and kept watching.

The arch lasted longest. After it fell, the guard held his hand in the old position for a little while.

A mound remained, a few shells and a bright scattering of grains. The wave drew back, carrying some away, leaving others a little farther along.

The child leaned forward.

“Will they be part of something else now?”

“They will,” said the dot.

“What?”

“Let's see.”

Far beneath their conversation, the quarks went about their business.

The universe was taking shape.

“Lisa!”

The little dot looked round.

That was her name now.

The wind stirred the hair on her forehead. Without thinking, she pressed her palm against the sand, but the wind had already passed.

A shell lay beside her. Lisa picked it up. Once, the carpenter had climbed inside and stayed until dark. Now the whole shell fitted in her hand.

The girl turned its opening towards her. Then she held it to her ear.

It murmured.

“Coming!” she called.

The shell fitted in her pocket too. Lisa felt it once more through the cloth.

Sand glinted by the water. She remembered the castle, its wide gates and the guard's hand still holding up an arch that had gone.

Lisa crouched beside the mark a wave had left.

“What happens next?” Margins

In the Margins: The One Button Museum

Can we open a museum if we've only found one button? Back to the story

I've lined a box with velvet. I'm making a label for the lid: ‘The One Button Museum’. Will you put the button in? Back to the story

Why does the button keep rolling into the corner? Back to the story

The velvet made a little hill. I've flattened it. Now the button stays in the middle. Back to the story

Who do we give tickets to if nobody knows about our museum yet? Back to the story

I've drawn two tickets. A man in a coat took one. A boy took the other, then went to fetch a magnifying glass. Back to the story

Why does our first visitor keep pointing at his coat? Back to the story

His coat has four buttons just like ours. Where the fifth should be, there are only a few threads. Back to the story

If we give the button back, what will be left in our museum? Back to the story

There'll still be the velvet. And the label. I've only just managed to stick it on straight. Back to the story

Let's give the button back. Can we carry it out on the lid? Back to the story

We carried the button on the lid, like a tray. The man held his coat closed and picked it up with two fingers. Back to the story

Don't close the lid yet. Back to the story

I was about to close the box when the boy arrived with his magnifying glass. He still had his ticket. Back to the story

Shall we tell the second visitor the button's gone? Back to the story

I told him we'd given it back. He looked into the box and asked if it was a big button. Back to the story

How can we show him what it was like? Back to the story